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Il tempo dell'apocalisse Vita di Gioacchino da Fiore. By Gian Luca Potestà. Pp. x+502+24 black-and-white and colour plates. Rome: Laterza, 2004. €48. 88 420 7320 2

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too much into his acceptance of Rashi. It is also important to remember that Herbert meant his literal readings to be only the basis for further exegetical delving. We keenly await the critical edition of Herbert's commentary on the Psalter by Eva de Visscher, another Herbert of Bosham scholar. But Goodwin's book is a must for anyone interested in twelfth-century biblical and intellectual history. It is only a pity that so many references were omitted from the index.

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In his ambitious study Gian Luca Potestà, already editor of two of Joachim of Fiore's earlier writings (*Dialogi de prescientia dei et predestinatione electorum*, Rome 1995, and 'Genealogia', DA lvi [2000], 91–101) now presents the first monograph on the life and work of the Calabrian abbot, biblical exegete and prophet (c. 1135–1202) since Majorie Reeves's ground breaking *Influence of prophecy in the later Middle Ages*, published in the 1960s. Unlike the English scholar, Potestà concentrates on Joachim's own lifetime and his immediate surroundings. The biography is linked and interwoven with the main events of twelfth-century Mediterranean history and with the abbot's literary production over nearly three decades, from the first text of 1176 until his unfinished late works. In the first of twelve chapters, Potestà provides an overview of the state of research and the extant sources. Then he follows Joachim's traces from the first evidence of his biography until he become abbot of Corazzo, the attempts to affiliate his monastery to the Cistercian houses of Sambucina and Casamari, his stay in Casamari and the beginnings of his literary production there, his treatise to and on Jews and the confrontation with heretics, the development of his Trinitarian theology of history and the awareness of the approaching end of times and expectation of the age of the Holy Spirit. Potestà explores Joachim's ambiguous attitude towards secular power compared with that of his contemporaries, mainly his enemy Geoffrey of Auxerre, and the role of Joachim's ascent to the Sila mountains in the Calabrian heartland, where he founded his new religious order. He describes Joachim's explanation of Revelation and the conclusions that followed, until towards the end of his life, when he tried to finish his latest writings, and wrote his testamentary letter which is preserved in the Venetian prints of 1527 and many of the manuscripts containing his writings. The author tries to sort out not only Joachim's sources but also contemporary influences and oral information which left their traces in his writings. He introduces and explains Joachim's imaginative thinking which depicts the history of salvation by means of biblical and classical motifs such as David's Psalter, Ezekiel's wheels or Pauline lists of concords between Old and New Testament. Moreover, Potestà contributes to ongoing debates on the main events of Joachim's life and the chronology of his writings, often raising new questions. Diagrams and tables enable the reader to visualise Joachim's figurative thought. A rich bibliography and a generally, though not always, precise index are helpful tools.

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